

PRANAB'S PRAISE FOR THE LEFT CAUSED HEARTBURN IN MAMATA'S TRINAMOOL.

BHATTACHARYA AND MUKHERJEE (RIGHT)



KOLKATA | Bonding Blues

On his recent visit to Kolkata, External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee heaped praise on West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya while announcing the launch of a new road in Murshidabad district and inaugurating a diabetes hospital. The proxy prime minister did not realise that such indulgence would raise eyebrows, particularly those of Trinamool Congress Chief Mamata Banerjee who is hoping to strike a deal with Sonia Gandhi before the Lok Sabha polls. Given that Mukherjee has been seen in the company of the chief minister on a regular basis, at inaugurations or chamber of commerce gatherings, no wonder Mamata feels a little Left Out these days. **by Abhijit Dasgupta**

FIFTY-YEAR-OLD WIRING, POOR EQUIPMENT AND CALLOUS STAFF—THE INCUBATOR FIRE IN PATIALA HOSPITAL WAS A TRAGEDY WAITING TO HAPPEN.

CHANDIGARH | Fuel to the Fire

With half-a-century-old electric wiring, ramshackle life-saving equipment and negligent staff, the death of five newborns in an incubator fire at the Rajindra Government Hospital in Patiala last week was a tragedy waiting to happen. The fire was caused by a short-circuit in the worn-out incubators made workable with wood encasings. The state Government was quick to suspend the principal of the Government Medical College and order a judicial probe. To make political capital out of the tragedy, Minister of Medical Education and Research Tikshan Sud resigned claiming 'moral responsibility' for the tragedy, rather than try to reassure shocked citizens that he could actually set things in order. **by Ramesh Vinayak**

GRIEVING RELATIVES



PATNA | On Record

Bihar's civil service has been short of officers for years. That's because the Bihar Public Service Commission (BPSC) has failed to hold regular exams. A simultaneous examination for five pending batches was conducted in 2008. Now, the Patna High Court has set aside the results of 48th to 52nd preliminary tests over anomalies in the question paper. Incidentally, former chief secretary A.K Choudhary, considered close to the Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, heads the BPSC.

by Amitabh Srivastava

CHOUHAN'S CABINET

BHOPAL | Mind Games

Under the stern gaze of party elders like Venkaiah Naidu, management gurus and shrinks, Shivraj Chouhan's cabinet colleagues were subjected to psychological tests and given leadership tips at a two-day workshop at Pachmarhi. The ministers fluffed a simple line on a communication test. "Obama warned Pakistan against going soft on Taliban" relayed through the Cabinet turned into "Obama was warned". Ministers were ticked off for being late and put through long hours of mental work. An impressed Chouhan now wants the workshop to be held every six months. **by Ambreesh Mishra**

PANKAJ TIWARI